globally as well as in the Indo–Pacific. This image is important for the Communist Party not so much internationally as domestically. It is a part of the image-cultivation that the Party does to earn legitimacy in the eyes of its own people. Much of the time the rest of the world buys into this image because of China's global importance, but this is also a vulnerability. The Chinese leadership is thin-skinned; unsettling them by impugning their self-image and how they want the rest of the world to view them can work to the other side's advantage.

Chinese behaviour during the episode of India's nuclear tests also uncovered another aspect of their diplomacy, this being that the Chinese will try to pursue their intended policy by hiding behind other countries or international public opinion. By claiming that China was only following the American lead and acting in line with international public anger against nuclear testing by India, it was initially able to disguise its own anti-India strategy and appear reasonable. As China has gained experience in multilateral diplomacy, it has begun to use this tool more effectively. It is now able to manipulate the system in order to stall and, if required, even to block outright, any developments that do not align with its core objectives, but always in the company of others. The trick lies in separating the Chinese from the pack, and in 'isolating' them, and thereafter keeping a steady course even if the Chinese use methods like intimidation, falsehoods, victimhood or fear psychosis to put maximum pressure on the perceived rival or adversary to change course.

If this does not succeed, China eventually reconciles to the situation and tries to find a way out. The Indian experience in 1998–1999 showed that a clear strategy coupled with a cogent and logical argument or narrative, and the ability to stay the course, could get the Chinese to change course. If the fog of confusion that China generates can be successfully dispelled